Suman Pandit, a Young Professional at the AIM, Niti Aayog is responsible for supporting various innovation initiatives to boost the culture of creativity, innovation and entrepreneurship in India

has spent the funds provided by the government. It typically includes details such as the initial balance, the amount received as a grant, and the ending balance, providing a clear account of how the funds were used. This certificate is a standard requirement for institutions that receive grants from the government. Additionally, every school needs to fill the ATL Dashboard every month, where they report their monthly activities

How do you audit the utilisation certificate?

The team reviews the utilisation certificate once the school submits it. The auditing process for the Atal Tinkering Labs program follows the established guidelines for all government schemes, overseen by the Ministry of Finance and the Department of Expenditure. This adherence to government auditing procedures ensures transparency and accountability in line with the programme's Central Sector status.

Who oversees the day-to-day functioning of ATLs?

Every Atal Tinkering Lab is assigned an ATL Incharge. This ATL Incharge is typically a science or computer teacher in the school, although there are no rigid restrictions. The ATL Incharge undergoes online training to acquire various skills related to running an ATL effectively, and they play a crucial role in facilitating the lab's activities and guiding the students.

How have you hired and deployed 10,000 trained technical instructors to remote Indian schools, considering the well-known shortage of quality teachers in these areas?

ATL does not appoint teachers in the schools; instead, the teachers are selected from the school's existing staff. Generally, the ATL Incharge is a science, computer, or physics teacher responsible for overseeing the ATL. These teachers balance their regular teaching duties with their role in managing the ATL. Having a dedicated resource person for the ATL is optional; it's often a shared responsibility within the school. We train these teachers on various aspects like robotics, 3D printing, and electronics through online tools and certification courses. There is a special certified online teacher training course designed for this. Additionally, we offer a tinkering curriculum designed in a three-level format (Level one, Level two, and Level three), and ATL Equipment Manual, which equips the teachers with the knowledge and materials they need to instruct their students effectively.

How do you keep track of the teachers' learning abilities?

We utilise an ATL dashboard to maintain detailed reports to keep track of the teacher's progress. The ATL dashboard is a vital tool for monitoring the performance of these labs. Additionally, our network of Mentors of Change, consisting of over 6,200 volunteers from diverse backgrounds, plays a crucial role in supporting schools and teachers in adopting innovative practices within the ATL ecosystem. Together, the ATL incharges, the dashboard, and the Mentors of Change are instrumental in our mission.

Who qualifies as a Mentor of Change, and how do they contribute to ATLs?

Anyone can apply to become a mentor of change, and we have a selection process in place. Typically, our mentors come from diverse backgrounds. Many are professors, entrepreneurs, artists, business professionals, and individuals passionate about STEM and innovation. We welcome people from all walks of life who want to contribute to the community and support the Atal Tinkering Labs programme.

How can someone become a Mentor of Change?

Becoming a Mentor of Change is open to everyone. Visit the official website of the Mentor of Change programme, where you will find an application form. The form typically delves into your background, community commitment, available time, and qualifications or higher education. The evaluation process determines eligibility. EFY